



DESTINATION FILE

Great Barrier Reef

One of Earth's great natural wonders — and the front line of climate-conscious tourism.

COUNTRY

Cairns & surrounds,
QLD

ACCESS

Fly to Cairns (CNS)

PAX RANKING

#4 of all destinations

STATUS

Open · reef health
critical

01 Destination overview

LOCATION & SIZE

The world's largest coral reef system — over 2,300 km along the Queensland coast, covering roughly 344,400 km². Visible from space, it comprises around 3,000 individual reefs and 900 islands. Cairns and Port Douglas are the primary gateways for Orange Journeys clients.

CHARACTER

A UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1981 and one of the most biodiverse ecosystems on Earth. The reef is also under severe climate pressure — making responsible, low-impact visitation more important than ever. Reef tourism directly funds much of the monitoring and conservation work that protects it.

ACCESS

Fly to Cairns Airport (CNS) — direct domestic and international services. Reef departures run from Cairns and Port Douglas marinas. The Spirit of Queensland train (Brisbane–Cairns) is a lower-carbon option for domestic travellers with time.

BEST SEASON

June–October (dry season) — best visibility, calm seas, mild temperatures, whale migration. November–May (wet season) — warmer water, stinger season (marine jellyfish), occasional cyclones. Coral spawning occurs after the November full moon.

GOVERNING BODIES

Great Barrier Reef Marine Park Authority (GBRMPA)

Reef Authority

Parks Australia

Queensland Parks & Wildlife

Traditional Owner groups

LEGAL FRAMEWORKS

Great Barrier Reef Marine Park Act 1975

EPBC Act 1999

Marine Parks zoning plans

High Standard Tourism Operator program

02 Traditional Owners & sea Country

TRADITIONAL OWNERS

More than 70 Traditional Owner groups hold connections to the Great Barrier Reef and its coast — their sea Country has been cared for over 60,000 years. Their knowledge increasingly informs reef management through formal partnerships with GBRMPA.

CULTURAL SIGNIFICANCE

The reef holds deep cultural, spiritual and economic significance for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples. Story places, song lines and traditional marine resource use continue today across the reef's length.

PRIORITY RECOMMENDATION

Choose operators with a Traditional Owner partnership or Indigenous-guided experience — Dreamtime Dive & Snorkel (Cairns) offers an Indigenous sea Country experience led by saltwater people, weaving culture with reef ecology.

03 Sustainability & current status

MASS BLEACHING • 2024-25

The reef suffered its fifth mass bleaching event in 2024, immediately followed by a sixth in 2025 — the first back-to-back bleaching years in recorded history. The 2024-25 AIMS report recorded the largest annual coral cover decline in 39 years of monitoring.

WHY IT'S HAPPENING

Climate-change-driven ocean heat stress is the primary cause. Marine heatwaves are now more frequent and severe, leaving less recovery time between events. Crown-of-thorns starfish outbreaks and poor water quality from coastal runoff compound the pressure.

WHAT'S BEING DONE

GBRMPA Reef 2050 Plan

Crown-of-thorns control program

Reef Restoration & Adaptation Program

Water quality improvement

Reef Census citizen science

BEFORE YOU SELL

Be honest with clients about reef health — overpromising pristine conditions risks disappointment and erodes trust. Frame a reef visit as supporting the monitoring and conservation economy. Choose High Standard Tourism Operators (HSTO) certified by GBRMPA.

04 Biodiversity & environment

WHY IT MATTERS

The reef supports an extraordinary web of life — its loss would cascade through the entire ecosystem and the communities that depend on it.

KEY WILDLIFE

400+ coral species

1,500+ fish species

Six of seven sea turtle species

Dugongs

Humpback whales (Jun-Oct)

Minke whales

Reef sharks

Giant clams

Maori wrasse

SPECIES TO KNOW

Green Sea Turtle

Endangered — major nesting at Raine Island. Keep 3–5m distance; never touch or chase.

Dugong

Vulnerable — seagrass grazer; vessel strike is a key threat. Reduce speed in seagrass areas.

Humpback Whale

Protected — migration Jun–Oct. Keep 100m (300m if calves present).

Maori Wrasse

Protected — iconic large reef fish. Do not feed; feeding alters natural behaviour.

WILDLIFE & REEF RULES

Use reef-safe, TGA-approved sunscreen — standard sunscreens damage coral. Never touch, stand on or kick coral. Stay 3–5m from free-swimming wildlife. Use moorings rather than anchoring. Take nothing — coral and shell collection is illegal.

05 Getting there sustainably

BY AIR

Cairns Airport (CNS) is the primary gateway, with direct domestic and international flights. Encourage non-stop routes where possible to reduce per-km emissions, and offer carbon offsetting for the flight legs as standard.

BY RAIL

The Spirit of Queensland (Brisbane–Cairns, ~25 hrs) is a meaningful lower-carbon alternative for east-coast travellers with time — a scenic journey in its own right.

ON THE REEF

All reef visits are by permitted operator vessels. Cairns and Port Douglas are walkable hubs; operators transfer guests directly to departure points, so no private car is needed once on the coast.

CHOOSING OPERATORS

Prioritise GBRMPA High Standard Tourism Operators — they meet the highest environmental and interpretation standards, and a portion of reef visitation fees funds the Marine Park's management directly.

06 Accessibility

OVERALL

Moderate — significantly better than many reef destinations, with some specialised operators.

ACCESSIBLE OPERATORS

Quicksilver Cruises (Port Douglas) operates a water-powered chair lift on its pontoon, allowing wheelchair users to enter the water for snorkelling, plus accessible toilets and boarding ramps — the first PADI Adaptive Service Facility on the reef. Sunlover Cruises offers wheelchair-accessible boarding and a dedicated deck space.

GREEN ISLAND

The most wheelchair-friendly reef island — accessed by jetty, no beach transfer required. Soft sand beyond the jetty is not wheelchair-friendly. Confirm vessel accessibility when booking.

Most operators provide written safety briefings on request as an alternative to verbal ones. PADI adaptive dive courses (Quicksilver) allow people with a range of physical disabilities to dive the reef.

ALWAYS DISCLOSE

Mobility requirements, disability details and medical conditions must be disclosed at booking, not on the day. Scuba participation may require an AS 4005.1 medical certificate for certain conditions.

Sources — Great Barrier Reef Marine Park Authority · AIMS Long-Term Monitoring Report 2024–25 · Reef Authority · Parks Australia · Tourism & Events Queensland. Reviewed at least every 12 months.
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